

# AI Now Institute 2023 Executive Summary: Confronting Tech Power

## Summary

## Summary: AI Now Institute 2023 Landscape Report — Confronting Tech Power

The AI Now Institute's 2023 Landscape Report argues that the central challenge posed by artificial intelligence is not the technology itself but the unprecedented concentration of economic and political power in the hands of a small number of large technology corporations—collectively termed "Big Tech." The report's thesis is that meaningful governance of AI requires directly confronting this structural power imbalance, moving beyond diagnoses of harm toward concrete regulatory and collective action.

The report identifies three dimensions through which Big Tech maintains dominance over AI development: a data advantage derived from extensive surveillance-based data collection; a computing power advantage rooted in control over cloud infrastructure, semiconductor supply chains, and specialized labor; and a geopolitical advantage sustained by narratives framing AI companies as indispensable national security assets, particularly through US-China competition rhetoric. These advantages create a self-reinforcing ecosystem in which even ostensibly independent AI startups remain structurally dependent on Big Tech resources, functioning less as competitors than as acquisition targets.

Four overarching strategic priorities structure the report's recommendations. First, the burden of demonstrating safety and compliance should fall on companies rather than on regulators or the public—analogous to due-diligence frameworks in finance, food, and pharmaceutical regulation. Second, policy silos between competition, privacy, and AI governance must be dismantled, as firms exploit disconnects between these domains to consolidate power—exemplified by Google's Privacy Sandbox, which leverages privacy rhetoric to undermine competitors. Third, advocates and policymakers must recognize when promising policy mechanisms, such as algorithmic audits and impact assessments, are co-opted by industry to displace stronger structural interventions like bans and bright-line rules. Fourth, strategies must extend beyond legislation to include worker organizing, shareholder advocacy, and coalition-building across sectors.

The report outlines seven specific policy windows: unwinding firms' data advantages through data minimization and privacy-competition linkages; reforming antitrust law and enforcement; regulating large-scale generative AI models such as ChatGPT; displacing audits as the primary accountability mechanism; future-proofing biometric surveillance regulation; enacting robust worker surveillance protections; and preventing digital trade agreements from preempting national AI regulation.

The broader significance of the report lies in its reframing of AI governance as fundamentally a question of corporate power rather than technological risk. By drawing parallels with historical movements against concentrated industrial power—Big Tobacco, Big Pharma, Big Oil—the Institute positions the current moment as one ripe for systemic reform, provided that civil society, regulators, and the public resist narratives equating technological advancement with inevitable progress and instead insist on democratic accountability over the trajectory of AI development.